

Animism and totems

Prehistoric religion is thought to have been animistic—imbuing the natural world, including the landscape and the animals that inhabited it, with magical or supernatural powers. Naturally distinctive geographical features, for example, a series of rock formations at Nyero in Uganda (possibly dating as far back as 12,000 years), became shrines. They were adorned with geometric paintings and visited by early peoples to make offerings to the spirits believed to be there. Animal-shaped carvings, often of human-animal hybrids, such as the 40,000-year-old “Lion Man” from a cave in southern Germany, were venerated, too. They were possibly a totem—a spirit animal with whom the tribe had a particular magical relationship.

Spirit world

Maintaining good relations with the many spirits who inhabited the world was vital for early peoples. Ritual specialists—often referred to as shamans—emerged to communicate with the spirits and try to influence them. Shamans could seemingly transport themselves to the realms of the spirits through trances brought on by chanting, the rhythmic banging of drums, or by smoking or ingesting hallucinogenic herbs or other psychotropic substances.



A headdress made of stag antlers found in the 11,000-year-old site of Star Carr in Yorkshire, may have been part of a shaman’s ritual attire, while rock art discovered in Siberia shows an “X-ray” view of the interior skeleton of the subject. This view is thought to represent the suspended state between life and death that allowed the shaman to travel into the spirit world. Such beliefs persisted among indigenous peoples in Siberia into modern times. The earliest beliefs in magic may date back 100,000 years, but many have survived, in some form, until very recently.

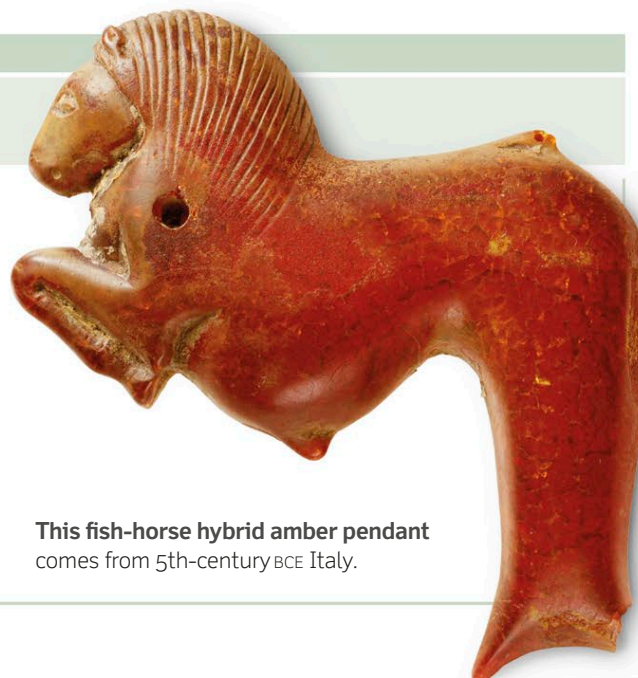
▲ Lascaux shaman

This cave painting shows a bison looming over a prostrate man next to a bird. One interpretation is that the figure depicted is a shaman and the bird is his spirit animal, traveling with him to the mystical realm while his body lies immobile in the physical one.

IN PRACTICE

Solidified sun

Amber, the fossilized resin of prehistoric pine trees, was treasured even in Neolithic times, and the ancient Greeks believed that it was the solidified rays of the sun. With its distinctive color and translucency, it became highly prized. It is electrostatic (it gives off sparks when rubbed), which also gave it a reputation for warding off danger, and it came to be regarded as a healing stone. Amber is found mainly along the shores of the Baltic Sea, but despite its comparative rarity necklaces and pendants made from it are a common archaeological find.



This fish-horse hybrid amber pendant comes from 5th-century BCE Italy.